

Chicago Tribune



QUESTIONS? CALL 1-800-TRIBUNE

TUESDAY, FEBRUARY 3, 2026

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Ill. joins World Health Organization network

Move follows Trump administration's withdrawal from group last month

By Lisa Schencker
Chicago Tribune

Illinois is joining a network of the World Health Organization in hopes of better positioning the state to handle potential health threats, following the U.S. withdrawal from the group last month. It's the state's latest move into

an area that was previously the domain of the federal government, before the administration of President Donald Trump began remaking public health policies and guidance. The Illinois Department of Public Health this week officially joined the World Health Organization's Global Outbreak Alert

and Response Network (GOARN), which provides resources and information intended to help control outbreaks and public health emergencies around the world. California announced that it was the first state to join the network late last month.

Illinois' decision to join GOARN follows the U.S. resigning from the World Health Organization late last month, citing the organization's "mishandling of the COVID-

Turn to Health, Page 2



Dr. Sameer Vohra, director of the Illinois Department of Public Health, speaks during an event in Chicago on Wednesday. Illinois decided to join GOARN partly to keep information flowing to the state, said Vohra. BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Millions raised fuel fights over seats

Candidates competing for 5 open seats ahead of March primary

By Olivia Olander, Robert McCoppin and Jack O'Connor
Chicago Tribune

With a little more than 40 days before a historic revamp of Illinois' congressional delegation begins to take shape with the March 17 primary, candidates for five open congressional seats began separating themselves from competitors by raising millions of dollars for their campaign funds.

The five heavily blue congressional districts that span from Algonquin through parts of Chicago and down to Danville have nearly four dozen Democrats competing to replace three retiring members of Congress and two who are running for the U.S. Senate.

In the highly competitive 9th Congressional District, where 15 Democrats are vying to replace retiring U.S. Rep. Jan Schakowsky representing parts of Chicago's North Side as well as north and northwest suburbs, two candidates began 2026 with more than \$1 million in their political bank accounts, and four others had at least \$500,000 ready to spend in the closing weeks of the campaign.

The nearby, northwest suburban 8th Congressional District features eight Democrats running to replace incumbent U.S. Rep. Raja Krishnamoorthi, who is seeking to succeed retiring U.S. Sen. Dick Durbin. A former member of Congress was the fundraising leader in that race, followed by an entrepreneur, a progressive who ran against Krishnamoorthi four years ago and a member of the

Turn to Seats, Page 5

Bill to legalize self-driving cars

A bill filed last week would authorize autonomous vehicle pilot programs in a handful of Illinois counties, including Cook, before opening the door to statewide legalization of self-driving cars in three years. Page 2

Chicago bank first to fail in 2026

Metropolitan Capital Bank & Trust was closed Friday by the Illinois Department of Financial and Professional Regulation, citing "unsafe and unsound conditions and an impaired capital position." Business



E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Anti-ICE protest

Students from Mather, Roosevelt, Amundsen and Northside College Prep high schools rally against Immigration and Customs Enforcement at River Park after walking out of school on Monday on Chicago's North Side. Chicagoland, Page 3



An activist records a federal agent on an immigration enforcement operation Monday in Minneapolis. RYAN MURPHY/AP

Minn. dad disputes government claim

Federal officials say boy abandoned, but parent declares love

By Mike Catalini, Steve Karnowski and Sharon Lurye
Associated Press

The father of a 5-year-old boy detained by immigration officers and held at a federal facility in Texas denied government accounts Monday that he abandoned

his son last month while being pursued by authorities.

As they returned to Minnesota, Adrian Conejo Arias, originally from Ecuador, told ABC News that he loves his son, Liam, and would never abandon him, disputing statements from the Department of Homeland Security, which alleged that Arias had left his child in a vehicle. He also said his son got sick while in federal custody but was denied medicine.

Assistant Homeland Security

Secretary Tricia McLaughlin said in a statement that Arias fled on foot before he was arrested, "abandoning his child." She said Immigration and Customs Enforcement officers stayed with the boy.

"The facts in this case have NOT changed: The father who was illegally in the country chose to take his child with him to a detention center," she said.

McLaughlin did not address

Turn to Dad, Page 9

'Only traitors help invaders'

U. of I. Republicans club faces backlash for post supporting ICE

By Kate Armanini and Rebecca Johnson
Chicago Tribune

The Illini Republicans club at the University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign is facing backlash after posting an illustration on social media of a masked gunman holding a weapon to a kneeling man's head — alongside the caption, "Only traitors help invaders."

The Instagram post, published Friday, also says Alex Pretti and Renée Good — who were both fatally shot by federal agents in Minneapolis last month — had "voided their liberties the moment they decided they were above the law."

"Our nation has come under invasion from the masses of the third world and those incompatible with Western civilization."

Turn to Club, Page 5

